

C-34
Study Guide

AGENDA: Strategies for the Transition of United Nations Peacekeeping Operations to a Sustainable Peacebuilding Presence.

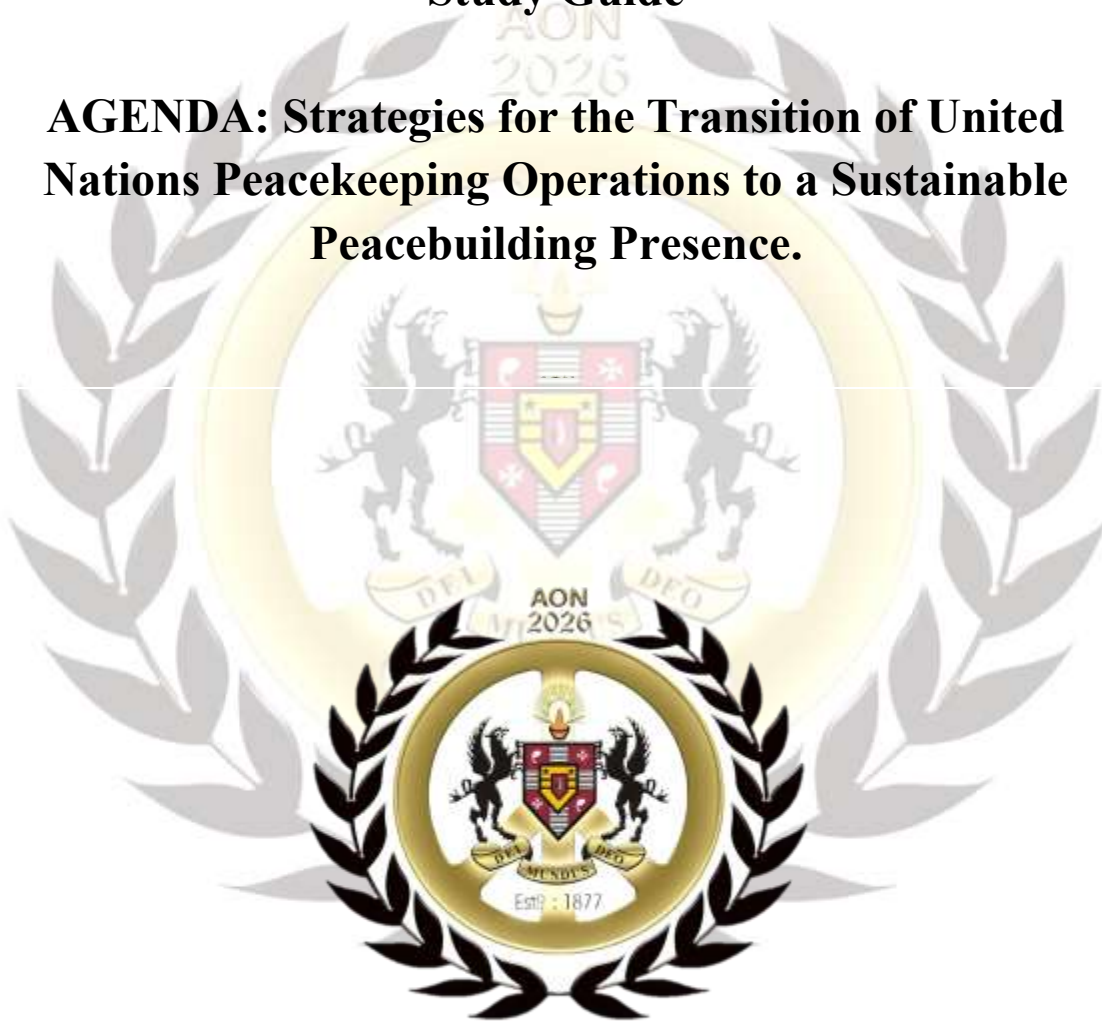


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A. Letter from the Executive Board

Esteemed Delegates,

On behalf of the Executive Board, it is our distinct honour to welcome you to the United Nations Security Council at the CBS Assembly of Nations Conference, 2026. This distinguished forum offers a unique opportunity to engage in diplomacy, refine leadership, and exercise communication marked by clarity, precision, and purpose. The sessions ahead will demand not only intellectual rigour but also a spirit of collaboration and respect for the multilateral process. While this background guide has been prepared to provide an initial framework for your deliberations, it is by no means exhaustive. Delegates are strongly encouraged to pursue independent, comprehensive research that transcends the scope of this document, thereby enriching the quality of debate and the substance of proposed solutions.

Given the gravity and complexity of the agenda, we urge you to arrive well-prepared, with a firm grasp of the relevant political, legal, and humanitarian dimensions. Your active engagement, constructive participation, and willingness to listen and lead will be critical to ensuring that our discussions remain substantive and solution-oriented. It is our aspiration that through this simulation, you will hone the art of negotiation, embrace the principles of consensus-building, and deepen your understanding of the challenges and responsibilities that define contemporary international security. This experience will not only enhance your diplomatic capabilities but will also inspire you to approach global issues with empathy, insight, and resolve. In this regard, we kindly ask each delegate to note that this will be an intensive simulation that may require pre-committee and post-committee engagement.

We look forward to your informed contributions and to the dynamic exchange of ideas that will undoubtedly emerge within this chamber. May your deliberations be marked by integrity, vision, and a commitment to the common good. We extend our best wishes for your preparation and success.

Yours sincerely,

The Executive Board.

B.1 Mandate of the Special Committee on Peacekeeping Operations (C-34)

The Special Committee on Peacekeeping Operations (C-34) is the principal body within the United Nations system mandated to conduct a comprehensive review of all issues relating to UN peacekeeping operations. It is not an operational or command body like the Security Council or the Department of Peace Operations; rather, it is a deliberative and policy-shaping committee of the General Assembly that examines how peacekeeping is planned, mandated, resourced and implemented. The C-34's work translates into detailed policy guidance and recommendations that frame the evolution of peacekeeping doctrine and practice, especially in areas such as mandate design, protection of civilians, safety and security of peacekeepers, and triangular cooperation among the Council, Secretariat and troop/police contributors.

The Committee's mandate originates in a 1965 General Assembly resolution that called for a Special Committee to review the whole question of peacekeeping operations in all their aspects. Over time, this mandate has been renewed and refined annually, giving the C-34 an ongoing role in assessing new operational challenges such as multidimensional mandates, robust use of force, peacekeeping–peacebuilding linkages, and the increasing complexity of host-State consent and partnership with regional organisations. Unlike the Security Council, the C-34 does not create binding obligations, but its consensus-based reports are treated as authoritative guidance by Member States and the Secretariat, shaping rules, standards and expectations for peacekeeping conduct.

The C-34 operates through an annual substantive session in New York, during which Member States debate a wide range of thematic and mission-specific issues, informed by reports of the Secretary-General and briefings from the Secretariat. The Committee's output is a comprehensive report negotiated paragraph by paragraph, which is then adopted by the General Assembly and becomes a key reference document for peacekeeping policy in the ensuing year. This gives the Committee a quasi-legislative character: it does not command troops or allocate budgets, but it elaborates the normative and operational framework within which peacekeeping is authorised and implemented. Its mandate is thus best understood as the institutionalisation of collective oversight and doctrinal development for peacekeeping, complementing the Security Council's collective security role.

The Committee's mandate also reflects a representational and participatory function. All Member States that are major troop- and police-contributing countries as well as major

financial contributors to peacekeeping can participate in the C-34, allowing those who bear the operational and financial burden of peacekeeping to shape its policies. In this way, the C-34 mitigates the structural imbalance between the Security Council's small membership and the wider UN membership by providing a forum where operational experience from the field, concerns of host States, and priorities of contributors can be channelled into formal recommendations. The C-34 therefore anchors peacekeeping in a broader base of State consent and collective deliberation, even though it lacks coercive powers.

B.2 Powers & Functions of the Special Committee on Peacekeeping Operations (C-34)

Under relevant General Assembly resolutions, the functions and powers of the C-34 are:

- to conduct a comprehensive review of the whole question of UN peacekeeping operations in all their aspects, including political, operational, financial and legal dimensions;
- to examine the implementation of existing peacekeeping mandates and policies, and to identify gaps, challenges and lessons learned;
- to formulate recommendations on the planning, conduct, management and support of peacekeeping operations, including doctrine, training, capabilities, and performance standards;
- to consider issues relating to the safety and security of peacekeepers, including casualty reduction, medical support, and accountability for attacks against UN personnel;
- to review and make recommendations on the protection of civilians, human rights, gender mainstreaming, and the conduct and discipline framework for peacekeepers, including prevention of sexual exploitation and abuse;
- to examine and promote strengthened triangular cooperation and consultation among the Security Council, troop- and police-contributing countries, and the Secretariat on mandate formulation and change;
- to review cooperation between the United Nations and regional and subregional organisations in peacekeeping, including burden-sharing, interoperability, and support arrangements;

- to provide guidance on capability development, including force generation, policing, specialized units, technology, and strategic enablers required for effective peacekeeping;
- to consider the linkages between peacekeeping and peacebuilding, including support for political processes, institution-building, rule of law and security sector reform within peacekeeping mandates;
- to report annually to the General Assembly, through a consensus report, with conclusions and recommendations that guide the future direction, reform and improvement of UN peacekeeping operations.

C.1 Foundational Resolution Establishing the C-34

The institutional history of the C-34 begins with **General Assembly resolution 2006 (XIX)** of 18 February 1965, which formally established the “Special Committee on Peacekeeping Operations”. This resolution responded to the growth and complexity of early UN operations (such as UNEF and ONUC) and recognised the need for a dedicated body to review “the whole question” of peacekeeping in all its aspects. Rather than leaving peacekeeping doctrine entirely to the Security Council and Secretariat, the General Assembly created a forum where the wider membership - especially troop- and police-contributing countries - could systematically examine lessons learned and recommend improvements.

Resolution 2006 (XIX) mandated the C-34 to conduct a comprehensive review of peacekeeping operations and to report back with recommendations. In doing so, it embedded peacekeeping oversight within the Assembly’s institutional architecture, under the Fourth Committee (Special Political and Decolonization). The resolution thus constitutionalised peacekeeping review as a standing function of the UN, transforming what had been ad hoc debates into a regularised, expert-driven process. Resolution 2006 (XIX) is therefore the constitutional charter of the C-34, analogous to how Article 24 of the Charter frames the Security Council’s primary responsibility for peace and security.

C.2 Annual C-34 Reports as “Soft Law” Frameworks

Unlike the Security Council, the C-34 does not typically adopt stand-alone, named thematic resolutions; instead, its influence operates through detailed **Annual Report of the Special Committee on Peacekeeping Operations** negotiated by consensus and then endorsed by the General Assembly. Each annual C-34 report functions as a quasi-legislative instrument: it consolidates Member States’ agreement on doctrine, priorities and reform directions across all major peacekeeping themes, from mandate design to conduct and discipline. When the General Assembly adopts the report, its recommendations become authoritative policy guidance for the Secretariat and peacekeeping stakeholders for the coming year.

Over time, these annual reports have addressed and progressively developed important “mini-regimes” within peacekeeping: mandate implementation; protection of civilians; safety and security of personnel; gender; training and performance; partnerships with regional organisations; and the peacekeeping–peacebuilding nexus. For instance, successive reports in the 2000s and 2010s elaborated detailed language on protection of civilians, clarifying that peacekeeping mandates must be matched with appropriate capabilities, intelligence, and rules of engagement, and stressing the need for accountability when missions fail to protect. In this sense, individual paragraphs of C-34 reports have become reference points in doctrinal debates, much like “interpretive resolutions” that guide later practice.

C.3 Resolutions and Processes Shaping C-34’s Contemporary Agenda

Several General Assembly resolutions outside the C-34 itself have also been important because they reshaped the Committee’s agenda and provided new frameworks that the C-34 then interpreted and operationalised. For example, the “**Action for Peacekeeping**” (A4P) initiative, endorsed by the General Assembly in 2018, set out a set of political commitments on more focused mandates, performance, and partnerships; subsequent C-34 reports have integrated A4P priorities and translated them into concrete recommendations on training, capabilities and triangular cooperation. Similarly, Assembly resolutions on the protection of civilians, women, peace and security, and the safety and security of peacekeepers have all generated clusters of issues that the C-34 must examine in detail and incorporate into its consensus language.

General Assembly resolution 55/235 of 23 December 2000 is the cornerstone text on the financing of UN peacekeeping operations. It reaffirms the general principles that underlie peacekeeping financing, including that: the costs of peacekeeping are expenses of the Organization to be borne by all Member States under Article 17(2) of the Charter; that peacekeeping financing is a collective responsibility of all States; that economically more developed States can contribute relatively more, while less developed States have limited capacity; and that special consideration should be given to States that are victims of or otherwise involved in events leading to a peacekeeping operation. The resolution also sets out the ten-level scale of assessments for peacekeeping contributions and links financing to the broader constitutional framework of the UN. For a C-34 study guide, this resolution is essential because it gives the constitutional and financial basis for how peacekeeping is funded and how Member States share that burden, which directly affects the feasibility of mandates that the C-34 reviews and recommends on.

General Assembly resolution 55/236, adopted on the same day as 55/235, deals with voluntary movements in the apportionment of peacekeeping expenses. It allows Member States to make voluntary commitments to contribute at a higher rate than their current assessment level during the scale period, by informing the General Assembly through the Secretary-General, and the Assembly may take note of that decision. This creates a mechanism for States to step up financially beyond their assessed rate, which can be politically important when missions face shortfalls or funding gaps. In relation to C-34, this resolution supports the idea that financing is not purely mechanical but can be adjusted through political will, which complements the Committee's recommendations on mandate design and capabilities

A/64/573 is the Secretary-General's 2009 report on the implementation of C-34 recommendations. It details how the Secretariat has followed up on the Committee's guidance from earlier sessions, translating recommendations into practical changes in mission design, training, capability development, conduct and discipline, and protection of civilians. This report demonstrates that the C-34 is part of a review–implementation cycle, not merely a deliberative forum, and creates an institutional expectation that the Secretariat must explain how C-34 recommendations are being implemented. For your study guide, this is a key document showing the operational weight of C-34 outputs.

A/72/573 is the Secretary-General's 2017 report on the implementation of C-34 recommendations, updating the picture from the earlier 2009 report and showing how the Secretariat has responded to newer recommendations on performance, accountability, triangular cooperation, and technology. This report reinforces the idea that C-34 recommendations generate an obligation of explanation and follow-up within the Secretariat, strengthening the argument that they have real practical consequences for mandate design and resource allocation. In doctrinal terms, this supports the view that the C-34 functions as a form of delegated policy-making body within the General Assembly.

Each year, the General Assembly, acting on the recommendation of the **Fifth Committee (Administrative and Budgetary)**, **approves the peacekeeping budget** for multiple missions and related entities such as logistics centres and the Support Account for Peacekeeping. For example, in June 2022 the Assembly approved \$6.45 billion for the 2022/23 budgets of peacekeeping missions, the United Nations Logistics Base, the Regional Service Centre in Entebbe, and the Support Account, and in July 2025 it approved \$5.4 billion for 2025/26, covering 12 missions and related logistics and support accounts. These budget resolutions implement the mandates and policy directions that are shaped, in part, by C-34 recommendations, linking political and operational decisions with financial and administrative decisions. For your study guide, these annual budget resolutions are the practical vehicle through which C-34's policy guidance is translated into actual funding for missions, capabilities, and support structures.

D. United Nations Special Committee on Peacekeeping Operations (C-34) and Its Relationship with Customary International Law

The relationship between the United Nations Special Committee on Peacekeeping Operations (C-34) and customary international law is nuanced because the Committee operates within the General Assembly as a deliberative, policy-shaping body, rather than as an organ with binding enforcement powers. The C-34 derives its mandate from General Assembly resolution 2006 (XIX) of 1965, which establishes it to conduct a comprehensive review of peacekeeping operations in all their aspects. Customary international law, by contrast, emerges from general and consistent State practice grounded in *opinio juris* - a sense of legal obligation. The C-34 is not itself a primary source of customary law in the way that States are, but its annual reports, consensus recommendations, institutional language, and the repeated practice of Member States within the Committee can strongly influence how customary international law related to peacekeeping develops, is interpreted, and is applied.

The C-34's first relationship with customary international law is evidentiary. The Committee's annual reports and negotiated consensus texts can serve as evidence of how States understand legal norms concerning peacekeeping, especially when reports are adopted without objection and reflect broad multilateral agreement. Since the C-34 comprises 157 Member States, including troop-, police-, and financial contributors as well as Permanent Members of the Security Council, its consensus positions may reflect collective legal opinion on matters such as mandate design, protection of civilians, safety and security of peacekeepers, conduct and discipline, gender mainstreaming, cooperation with regional organisations, and the peacekeeping–peacebuilding nexus. For example, the repeated inclusion of protection of civilians language in successive C-34 reports - starting notably with the 2009 report (A/63/19) - has helped consolidate the position that protecting civilians is not merely a political preference but a core normative expectation within peacekeeping mandates. Similarly, the Committee's consistent emphasis on the safety and security of peacekeepers, accountability for attacks on UN personnel, and prevention of sexual exploitation and abuse reinforces the customary and treaty-based idea that these are matters of universal concern, even though the C-34 acts through recommendations rather than binding authorisations.

The C-34 can also contribute to the crystallisation and gradual development of emerging customary norms. Where a legal principle is still developing, the Committee's repeated practice and consensus recommendations can accelerate its movement from political expectation to legal norm by shaping the legal consciousness of States and international organisations. The C-34's treatment of mass atrocities, civilian protection, conflict-related sexual violence, and women's participation in peace processes has contributed to the broader normative architecture around protection of civilians and gender in peacekeeping, even if the precise content of these norms remains contested in specific contexts. For instance, the Committee's recommendations on women, peace and security, often aligned with General Assembly resolutions and Security Council Resolution 1325, did not create customary law in and of themselves, but they helped institutionalise expectations regarding women's participation, protection, and gender-sensitive peacebuilding within peacekeeping operations. Over time, such repeated consensus practice can strengthen the normative weight of these principles and influence how States and the Secretariat interpret their obligations.

However, the C-34 cannot simply override customary international law at will, nor can it manufacture custom in isolation from States. Although the General Assembly's resolutions and the C-34's reports carry significant political and institutional authority, the Committee remains bound by the UN Charter's purposes and principles, and its recommendations are not binding on Member States in the same way as Security Council Chapter VII resolutions. At a minimum, the C-34's recommendations cannot lawfully authorise or encourage conduct that violates *jus cogens* norms, such as genocide, slavery, torture, racial apartheid, or aggressive war. These peremptory norms occupy a higher position within international law and cannot be displaced by ordinary treaty obligations or institutional decisions, including those of the General Assembly or its subsidiary bodies. Therefore, even though the C-34's consensus reports are treated as authoritative guidance by the Secretariat and Member States, their normative weight is not detached from the broader hierarchy of international law.

The most important tension arises when the Committee's recommendations appear to interact with or seek to clarify customary rules on sovereignty, non-intervention, immunity, due process, or the use of force in peacekeeping contexts. For example, C-34 recommendations on robust mandates, use of force to protect civilians, and partnerships with regional organisations have raised questions about the boundaries of host-State consent, the scope of permissible force, and the legal status of regional operations acting alongside or under UN mandates. The

Committee's guidance on triangular cooperation among the Security Council, troop- and police-contributing countries, and the Secretariat has also generated debates over whether the C-34 is clarifying existing customary obligations or reshaping the expectations surrounding mandate formulation and implementation. Yet the fact that C-34 reports are negotiated paragraph by paragraph and adopted by consensus shows that the Committee does not automatically settle customary law; it may instead produce or reflect contestation over the meaning and limits of the norm, particularly when States have divergent views on the scope of protection mandates or the use of force.

The C-34's relationship with customary international law is therefore dialectical. On the one hand, the Committee derives legitimacy from existing customary principles such as sovereign equality, non-use of force except in authorised contexts, self-defence, humanitarian protection, and cooperation against international crimes. Its work is anchored in the Charter's framework and in the broader consensus of Member States that peacekeeping must be conducted in accordance with international law. On the other side, the Committee's practice contributes to the interpretation, consolidation, and sometimes transformation of those principles. It can clarify what counts as an appropriate peacekeeping mandate, strengthen obligations of prevention and cooperation, and create patterns of expectation that later influence how States and international organisations understand their customary obligations in peacekeeping contexts. But it cannot manufacture custom in isolation from States, nor can it lawfully act outside the fundamental limits of the Charter and peremptory international law. In doctrinal terms, the C-34 functions as a form of delegated policy-making and norm-shaping body within the General Assembly, whose outputs feed into the operational practice of the Secretariat and the conduct of Member States, thereby contributing to the gradual formation and interpretation of customary international law on peacekeeping.

E. Introduction to the Agenda: Strategies for the Transition of UN Peacekeeping Operations to a Sustainable Peacebuilding Process

UN peacekeeping has entered its most structurally complex phase since the post-Cold War expansion of multidimensional mandates. What distinguishes the current transition challenge from prior cycles of mission closure and reconfiguration is the simultaneous erosion of multiple peacebuilding architectures across six interlocking dimensions - fragile and often declining host-State consent, contested and ambiguous mandate legacies, unresolved or incomplete security-sector reform, weak or non-existent political compacts, severely underfunded and under-resourced peacebuilding instruments, and fragmented coordination between peacekeeping operations and peacebuilding mechanisms across the UN system. These are not parallel problems that can be addressed in isolation. They are mutually reinforcing fault lines operating within a single peacekeeping system where mandate design, operational capabilities, political strategy, financial resources, and institutional linkages intersect at unprecedented density.

The transition from peacekeeping to sustainable peacebuilding is no longer a linear administrative exercise of drawing down troops and closing missions. It has become a fundamentally political and strategic problem that requires coordinated action across the Security Council, the General Assembly, the Secretariat, troop- and police-contributing countries, host States, and regional organisations. The C-34 exists precisely to address this complexity: it is the principal body within the UN system mandated to conduct a comprehensive review of all issues relating to peacekeeping operations, including the critical question of how missions transition from security-focused operations to politically grounded peacebuilding processes. Its annual reports, negotiated by consensus among 157 Member States, have progressively elaborated doctrine on mandate endings, political transitions, capability gaps, and the peacekeeping–peacebuilding nexus, yet the operational reality remains that many missions have closed without leaving sustained peace, while others have struggled to renew mandates or adapt to shifting political contexts.

The current agenda therefore confronts a set of structural tensions that define the transition problem. On one side, the Security Council retains the power to authorise and terminate mandates, often under time pressure and political imperatives that prioritise short-term security

gains over long-term political sustainability. On the other side, the C-34 and the General Assembly provide the forum where troop- and police-contributing countries, many of whom bear the operational and financial burden of peacekeeping, can shape policy guidance on transition strategies, performance standards, and triangular cooperation. Between these two poles sits the Secretariat, which must translate mandate language into operational plans, budgetary allocations, and field-level implementation while managing the expectations of host States, regional partners, and international donors. The challenge is that transition is often treated as an endpoint rather than a continuous political process, and peacebuilding is often treated as a separate phase rather than an integrated dimension of peacekeeping from the outset.

What makes this agenda particularly urgent is the growing evidence that transitions without robust peacebuilding foundations have produced fragile outcomes, recurrent violence, and in some cases complete mission failure. Missions in Haiti, Liberia, and the Central African Republic have faced difficulties in sustaining political progress after drawdown, while missions in Mali, the Democratic Republic of Congo, and South Sudan have struggled with contested exits and unresolved security threats. At the same time, the UN's peacebuilding instruments - including the Peacebuilding Fund, the Peacebuilding Support Office, and national peacebuilding commissions - remain underfunded relative to the scale of peacekeeping operations, and coordination between security and political actors remains ad hoc rather than systematic. The C-34's recommendations on triangular cooperation, mandate design, performance accountability, and regional partnerships are therefore not merely policy suggestions; they are essential inputs into a broader reform agenda that seeks to align peacekeeping mandates with peacebuilding realities from the outset of mission deployment.

This agenda therefore asks the C-34 to address a set of core strategic questions: How can peacekeeping mandates be designed from the outset to embed peacebuilding priorities rather than treating them as a post-mission add-on? How can host-State consent be cultivated and maintained through political compacts that link security operations to legitimate governance, rule of law, and inclusive political processes? How can security-sector reform be completed or at least rendered sustainable before missions draw down, rather than leaving unfinished reform that becomes a source of instability? How can the UN better align peacekeeping budgets, capabilities, and timelines with peacebuilding instruments, donor commitments, and national priorities? How can triangular cooperation among the Security Council, troop- and police-contributing countries, and the Secretariat be strengthened to ensure that transition strategies

are collectively owned and politically coherent? And how can regional organisations be integrated into transition planning in ways that leverage their local knowledge, political access, and operational capacity while preserving the Council's role as the source of universal legal legitimacy?

The stakes of this agenda extend beyond any single mission or region. They touch on the very legitimacy and effectiveness of UN peacekeeping as an instrument of collective security and peacebuilding. If the UN cannot transition peacekeeping operations to sustainable peacebuilding processes, then peacekeeping risks becoming a cycle of deployed missions, contested exits, and recurrent violence that undermines confidence in the UN's capacity to maintain international peace and security. If the C-34 can help articulate and operationalise a coherent transition framework, then peacekeeping can evolve from a security-focused intervention into a politically grounded process that leaves behind durable institutions, inclusive governance, and resilient communities. The agenda before the Committee is therefore not merely technical; it is fundamentally political, doctrinal, and strategic, and it requires the C-34 to exercise its unique mandate to review, recommend, and shape the future direction of UN peacekeeping operations.

F1. Active United Nations Peacekeeping Operations

The United Nations currently deploys a set of active peacekeeping operations that form the operational context for the C-34's review of transition strategies and sustainable peacebuilding. As of 2026, the Department of Peace Operations oversees **eleven ongoing peacekeeping missions**, with more than 50,000 peacekeepers serving across Africa, the Middle East, Europe, and Asia. These missions are not uniform in their mandates, sizes, or operational challenges; they reflect a spectrum of security environments, from observer missions monitoring long-standing confrontations to multidimensional operations engaged in complex political transitions, security-sector reform, and civilian protection.

The African operations constitute the largest and most politically complex cluster of current peacekeeping missions.

Central African Republic, the **United Nations Multidimensional Integrated Stabilization Mission in the Central African Republic (MINUSCA)** remains one of the largest and most robust peacekeeping operations, mandated to protect civilians, support the political process, and help implement the national peace agreement in a context of ongoing armed group violence and state fragility.

In the **Democratic Republic of the Congo**, the **United Nations Organization Stabilization Mission in the Democratic Republic of the Congo (MONUSCO)** has operated for over a decade, tasked with protecting civilians, supporting the government in stabilisation efforts, and addressing the presence of numerous armed groups in the eastern provinces, though its mandate has been progressively scaled down in response to host-State pressure and changing security dynamics.

In **South Sudan**, the **United Nations Mission in the Republic of South Sudan (UNMISS)** continues to protect civilians, monitor human rights, and support the implementation of the Revitalised Peace Agreement, operating in a context where political commitments remain fragile and violence periodically resurges despite the formal end of large-scale civil war.

In **Abyei**, the **United Nations Interim Security Force for Abyei (UNISFA)** monitors the demilitarised zone between Sudan and South Sudan, protects civilians, and facilitates humanitarian access in a region where tensions over borders, resources, and governance remain unresolved despite the mission's long-standing presence.

In **Western Sahara**, the **United Nations Mission for the Referendum in Western Sahara (MINURSO)** remains an observer mission tasked with monitoring the ceasefire between Morocco and the Frente POLISARIO, though its original mandate to organise a referendum on self-determination has not been realised, and the mission has become a focal point of debates over the UN's role in unresolved territorial conflicts.

In the **Middle East**, three long-standing observer and peacekeeping missions continue to operate in contexts of stagnant political progress and recurring violence. The **United Nations Disengagement Observer Force (UNDOF)** monitors the ceasefire between Israel and Syria in the Golan Heights, operating in a region where the original disengagement agreement has never been fully implemented and where regional tensions periodically threaten the stability of the ceasefire.

The **United Nations Peacekeeping Force in Cyprus (UNFICYP)** maintains a presence in Cyprus to prevent further fighting and to contribute to the maintenance and restoration of peace, operating in a divided island where the political resolution of the Cyprus question remains unresolved despite decades of UN-mediated negotiations.

The **United Nations Interim Force in Lebanon (UNIFIL)** monitors the cessation of hostilities between Israel and Lebanon, assists the Lebanese Armed Forces in establishing a non-explosive area in southern Lebanon, and supports humanitarian access, operating in a volatile context where regional tensions and internal political fragility continue to shape the security environment.

In the broader Middle East, the **United Nations Truce Supervision Organization (UNTSO)** remains the UN's oldest peacekeeping mission, deploying military observers to monitor armistice agreements and maintain peace in the region since 1948, serving as a foundational observer presence that has informed the development of UN peacekeeping doctrine over decades.

In **Europe**, the **United Nations Interim Administration Mission in Kosovo (UNMIK)** continues to administer Kosovo under a framework established in 1999, facilitating dialogue between communities, supporting the development of democratic institutions, and contributing to the maintenance of stability in a region where the political status of Kosovo remains contested and where relations between Kosovo and Serbia remain fragile despite international engagement.

In **Asia**, the **United Nations Military Observer Group in India and Pakistan (UNMOGIP)** continues to monitor the ceasefire line in Jammu and Kashmir, an operation that has persisted since 1949 despite the absence of a comprehensive political resolution to the India-Pakistan dispute over Kashmir and despite periodic tensions along the line of control

These missions collectively represent the operational reality that the C-34 must confront when considering strategies for the transition of UN peacekeeping operations to sustainable peacebuilding processes. Some missions, such as MINUSCA and MONUSCO, operate in contexts of ongoing violence and weak state capacity, where transition is contingent on political settlements, security-sector reform, and the gradual consolidation of state authority. Others,

such as UNIFIL, UNDOF, UNFICYP, and UNMOGIP, operate in contexts of unresolved political disputes where the primary function is to monitor ceasefires and prevent escalation, with no clear political pathway to mission closure. Still others, such as UNMISS and UNISFA, operate in post-conflict environments where formal peace agreements exist but implementation remains fragile and where violence can resurge despite the absence of large-scale civil war. Still others, such as MINURSO and UNMIK, operate in contexts of frozen conflicts where the original mandate has not been fulfilled and where political progress has stalled despite decades of UN engagement.

The C-34's agenda on transition strategies must therefore address a spectrum of mission types, each with distinct transition challenges. For multidimensional missions in active conflict environments, transition requires not only security drawdown but also the completion or sustainable handover of security-sector reform, the consolidation of political compacts, and the establishment of resilient institutions that can maintain peace without UN presence. For observer missions in frozen conflicts, transition may not be politically feasible in the near term, and the focus must instead shift to sustaining ceasefire monitoring, preventing escalation, and supporting regional diplomacy. For post-conflict missions in fragile peace environments, transition requires careful sequencing of drawdown with political engagement, ensuring that security vacuums do not emerge and that peacebuilding instruments are adequately resourced to sustain progress after mission closure. Across all mission types, the C-34 must consider how to align mandate design, capabilities, budgets, and timelines with peacebuilding realities from the outset of deployment, rather than treating peacebuilding as a post-mission add-on. The active peacekeeping operations listed above are not merely operational facts; they are the concrete contexts in which the C-34's recommendations on transition and sustainable peacebuilding must be tested, refined, and operationalised.

F2. The Three Pillars of UN Peace Operations - Peacemaking, Peacekeeping, and Peacebuilding

The United Nations framework for addressing conflict and sustaining peace is structured around three distinct but interlocking pillars: **peacemaking**, **peacekeeping**, and **peacebuilding**. These pillars are not sequential phases where one ends and the next begins; they are constitutive elements of a single integrated approach to maintaining international peace and security. The Security Council authorises mandates, the General Assembly and the C-34 review and recommend policy guidance, and the Secretariat implements operational plans, all within this triangular architecture. Understanding the doctrinal, institutional, and operational distinctions between these pillars is essential for the C-34's agenda on transition strategies, because the challenge of moving from peacekeeping to sustainable peacebuilding is not a technical exercise of drawing down troops but a strategic problem of aligning all three pillars so that political engagement, security operations, and long-term institution-building reinforce one another rather than operate in isolation.

The first pillar is **peacemaking**, the political dimension of UN operations that seeks to prevent conflict, resolve ongoing disputes, and facilitate inclusive dialogue through diplomatic, negotiation-based, and mediation mechanisms. Peacemaking is grounded in Chapter VI of the UN Charter, which deals with the “*peaceful settlement of disputes*,” and it encompasses the activities of the Secretary-General, the Security Council, the General Assembly, regional organisations, and special political missions working to bring parties to a conflict to agree on a political solution. Peacemaking includes high-level diplomacy by the Secretary-General or their special representatives, mediation of peace agreements, support for constitutional and electoral processes, facilitation of national dialogue, and engagement with regional and international partners to build political consensus. The UN's special political missions - such as the **United Nations Assistance Mission in Afghanistan (UNAMA)**, the **United Nations Office for West Africa and the Sahel (UNOWAS)**, the **United Nations Special Commission for Lebanon (UNSMIL)**, and the **United Nations Assistance Mission for Iraq (UNAMI)** - are institutional vehicles for peacemaking, deploying political officers, mediators, and electoral experts to support peace processes without deploying military forces. Peacemaking is the foundation upon which both peacekeeping and peacebuilding rest: without a credible political pathway, peacekeeping operations risk becoming open-ended security interventions, and peacebuilding efforts risk becoming technocratic exercises disconnected from political

realities. The C-34's recommendations on political processes have consistently emphasised that mandate design must be aligned with political compacts that link security operations to legitimate governance, rule of law, and inclusive political processes, and that host-State consent must be cultivated and maintained through engagement with elites, communities, and civil society. The challenges of political fragmentation in missions such as Mali, the Democratic Republic of Congo, and South Sudan illustrate the risks of peacemaking being undermined by elite exclusion, rejection of UN engagement, or lack of regional support.

The second pillar is **peacekeeping**, the security-focused dimension of UN operations that deploys military, police, and civilian personnel to monitor ceasefires, protect civilians, support government authority, and create conditions for political progress. Peacekeeping operations are authorised by the Security Council under Chapter VI or Chapter VII of the UN Charter, and their mandates range from simple observer missions monitoring armistice agreements to multidimensional operations engaged in complex stabilisation, civilian protection, and security-sector reform. The C-34's annual reports have progressively elaborated doctrine on peacekeeping capabilities, performance standards, use of force, safety and security of personnel, conduct and discipline, gender mainstreaming, and the relationship between peacekeeping and host-State consent. Peacekeeping is the most visible and operationally intensive pillar, with more than 50,000 peacekeepers serving across eleven current missions in Africa, the Middle East, Europe, and Asia, but it is not self-sustaining: its legitimacy depends on peacemaking, its effectiveness depends on peacebuilding foundations, and its transition depends on the integration of all three pillars from the outset of mission deployment. Missions such as **MINUSCA** in the Central African Republic, **MONUSCO** in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, and **UNMISS** in South Sudan illustrate the operational complexity of peacekeeping in active conflict environments, where peacekeepers are tasked with protecting civilians under imminent threat, supporting stabilisation efforts, and helping implement national peace agreements in contexts of ongoing armed group violence and state fragility. Missions such as **UNDOF** in the Golan, **UNFICYP** in Cyprus, **UNIFIL** in Lebanon, **UNMOGIP** in India and Pakistan, and **MINURSO** in Western Sahara illustrate the observer and ceasefire-monitoring functions that remain critical in frozen or stagnant conflicts where the primary role is to prevent escalation rather than to engage in stabilisation. Missions such as **UNISFA** in Abyei and **UNMIK** in Kosovo illustrate the long-standing presence of

peacekeeping operations in contexts where political status remains contested and where the original mandate has not been fully realised despite decades of UN engagement.

The third pillar is **peacebuilding**, the long-term dimension of UN operations that seeks to prevent the recurrence of conflict by addressing root causes, strengthening institutions, and fostering inclusive political and social processes. Peacebuilding encompasses security-sector reform, rule of law, justice and accountability, human rights protection, gender mainstreaming, economic recovery, public administration, and the development of democratic institutions. The UN's peacebuilding instruments - including the **Peacebuilding Fund**, the **Peacebuilding Support Office**, and **national peacebuilding commissions** - are designed to support these processes, but they remain underfunded relative to the scale of peacekeeping operations, and coordination between security and political actors remains ad hoc rather than systematic. The C-34's recommendations on the peacekeeping–peacebuilding nexus have consistently called for peacebuilding priorities to be embedded in peacekeeping mandates from the outset, rather than treated as a post-mission add-on, and for better alignment of peacekeeping budgets, capabilities, and timelines with peacebuilding instruments, donor commitments, and national priorities. Missions that have closed without leaving sustained peace, such as those in **Haiti** and **Liberia**, illustrate the risks of peacebuilding being marginalised or under-resourced, while ongoing challenges in **Mali**, the **Democratic Republic of the Congo**, and **South Sudan** illustrate the difficulties of completing security-sector reform and consolidating political compacts before missions draw down. The Peacebuilding Fund has supported over 100 projects in more than 40 countries, providing critical resources for early recovery, conflict prevention, and reconciliation, but its total funding remains a fraction of the annual peacekeeping budget, which exceeded \$6 billion in 2025 for 12 missions and related logistics and support accounts.

The three pillars are interdependent, and the challenge of transition is the challenge of aligning them so that they reinforce one another. Peacemaking without peacekeeping and peacebuilding creates fragile agreements that are undermined by insecurity and institutional weakness. Peacekeeping without peacemaking creates open-ended security interventions that lack political legitimacy and are vulnerable to host-State rejection. Peacebuilding without peacemaking and peacekeeping creates technocratic institutions that lack legitimacy and are

vulnerable to political capture. The C-34's agenda on transition strategies must therefore address how to design peacekeeping mandates from the outset to embed peacemaking and peacebuilding priorities, how to cultivate and maintain host-State consent through political compacts that link security operations to legitimate governance, how to complete or at least render sustainable security-sector reform before missions draw down, how to align peacekeeping budgets, capabilities, and timelines with peacebuilding instruments, donor commitments, and national priorities, and how to strengthen triangular cooperation among the Security Council, troop- and police-contributing countries, and the Secretariat so that transition strategies are collectively owned and politically coherent. The stakes of this agenda extend beyond any single mission or region: they touch on the very legitimacy and effectiveness of UN peace operations as an instrument of collective security and peacebuilding. If the UN cannot align the three pillars so that they reinforce one another, then peace operations risk becoming a cycle of deployed missions, contested exits, and recurrent violence that undermines confidence in the UN's capacity to maintain international peace and security. If the C-34 can help articulate and operationalise a coherent framework for aligning peacemaking, peacekeeping, and peacebuilding, then peace operations can evolve from security-focused interventions into politically grounded processes that leave behind durable institutions, inclusive governance, and resilient communities.

Good Luck!